



Cup, through grassroots development.

“Academies are not just meant to build players; they are long-term assets for the country,” Subrata Paul, the director of the national team, tells *Sportstar*. “They are the heart and soul of a country’s footballing future.”

So, why has it not been successful in transforming India?

A late start

The Long-Term Athlete Development (LTAD) plan, developed by sports scientist Dr. Istvan Balyi, is one of the most globally accepted models for youth development, in football and otherwise.

Stage 1: Active Start (0-6 years old)

Stage 2: FUNdamental (6-9)

Stage 3: Learn to Train (9-12)

Stage 4: Train to Train (12-16)

Stage 5: Train to Compete (16-19)

Stage 6: Train to Win (19+)

Stage 7: Active for Life (any age)

Accordingly, most academies in leading footballing countries admit recruits from Stage 2 — having scouted the best from Stage 1 — typically at the age of six. Case in point — La Masia (Barcelona), Ajax Amsterdam, and Bayern Munich. Spain and Barcelona sensation Lamine Yamal joined La Masia when he was seven.

In India, the starting age for football academies is typically 12 — double the global standard — missing an entire stage of cognitive and physical development.

“I believe India has always invested a lot in education. But football is not like any other job. Unfortunately, it starts at a very young age. You cannot start to play football at 15 years of age. You have to start at 5-6 years because you have

Patient rebuild: ‘Patience is bitter, but its fruit is sweet’ — India needs to accept the mess it is in and ride on patience and hard work to grow the beautiful game. AIFF MEDIA

to find your feet,” former Arsenal manager Arsene Wenger had said during his visit to India two years ago.

“When we started, we kept the minimum age at eight. But there are no competitions. I can’t keep training them all day without testing them,” rues Ranjit Bajaj, the founder of Minerva Academy, one of the few to field teams in every age-group tournament in India.

“It’s hardly productive. So, we eventually moved to 12.”

Though the country now has a league for kids between ages 6-12,